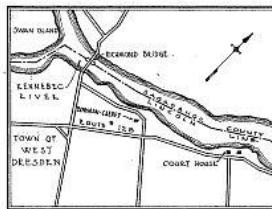


POWNBOROUGH COURT HOUSE

CEDAR GROVE
LINCOLN COUNTY
MAINE



SKETCH MAP
SHOWING LOCATION

ERECTED 1761

HISTORIC AMERICAN BUILDINGS SURVEY
U.S. DEPARTMENT OF THE INTERIOR
NATIONAL PARK SERVICE
BRANCH OF PLANS AND DESIGN

MEASURED: JULY 7, 1926 - JULY 20, 1926
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POWNALBOROUGH COURT HOUSE

The 1936 Historic American Buildings Survey

Aric Wilmunder

A Well-Regulated Press

Novato, California

2026

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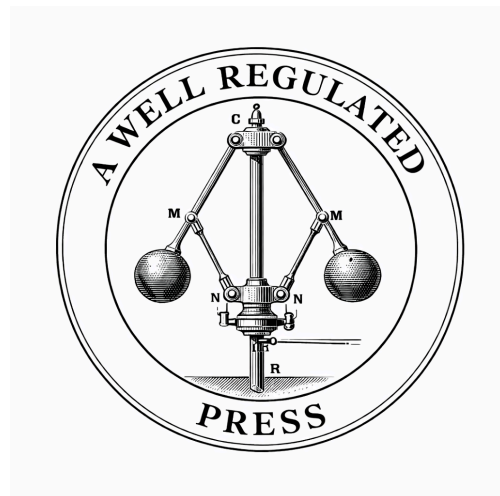
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Preface

Historic buildings connect us to the people who came before us. Their walls have witnessed public debates, quiet conversations, celebrations, hardships, and the ordinary routines of everyday life. Some of these stories survive in letters, diaries, newspapers, and photographs. Others remain written into the buildings themselves, waiting to be discovered in worn stair treads, hand-forged hinges, weathered timbers, and carefully crafted woodwork.

The Pownalborough Court House, completed in 1761, is one of Maine's oldest surviving public buildings. It served as the seat of government for Lincoln County before becoming the home of the Johnson and Prescott families in the nineteenth century. Today it is preserved as a museum, allowing visitors to experience more than two and a half centuries of Maine history under one roof.

By the 1930s, many of America's historic buildings had already been altered or lost. Recognizing the need to preserve an accurate record of the nation's architectural heritage, the federal government established the Historic American Buildings Survey (HABS) in 1933. Just three years later, a team of architects and draftsmen arrived at the Pownalborough Court House to create one of the earliest comprehensive architectural records of the building.

Over the course of their survey, they measured rooms, fireplaces, stairways, windows, doors, and structural framing, recording details that might otherwise have been forgotten. Their work produced nineteen meticulously drafted sheets that remain one of the most valuable resources for understanding the courthouse not just as it appeared in 1936, but also as it had evolved over time. The drawings include historical notes on everything from its earlier shingled appearance to features that had been modified since the original construction.

At first glance, these drawings may seem intended only for architects or historians. In reality, they tell a much broader story. They reveal how the courthouse was constructed, how it evolved over time, and how its original eighteenth-century features could be distinguished from later alterations. They also offer a fascinating glimpse into the methods and standards of one of America's earliest historic preservation programs.

This guide was created to help readers explore that survey. Rather than simply reproducing the drawings, it explains what each sheet documents, why it was prepared, and what it reveals about the building. Whether you are visiting the courthouse for the first time, researching its history, studying early American architecture, or simply curious about how historic buildings are documented, these pages are intended to make one of the nation's finest architectural surveys accessible to everyone.

Chapter 1

The Historic American Buildings Survey (HABS)

Preserving America's Architectural Heritage

Historic buildings are among our nation's most tangible connections to the past. They preserve the craftsmanship, materials, and architectural traditions of earlier generations while providing a physical setting for the events that shaped local communities and the nation as a whole. Every hand-hewn timber, worn floorboard, and carefully carved molding reflects the skills of the people who built them and the lives of those who later occupied them.

By the early twentieth century, however, many of America's oldest buildings were disappearing. Expanding cities, changing transportation networks, economic pressures, and modern construction practices led to the demolition or alteration of countless historic structures. While some buildings were preserved through local efforts, many others vanished without leaving behind an accurate record of their appearance or construction.

Architects, historians, and preservationists recognized that once a building was lost, so too was much of the knowledge it contained. If every room, doorway, staircase, fireplace, and structural detail could be measured and recorded, future generations would still be able to study these remarkable buildings even if they no longer survived. Accurate measured drawings, accompanied by photographs and written histories, offered a way to preserve America's architectural heritage for future generations.